

A website and an app, built for the store you already made.

You've got 4,800 people following you and 315 reviews at 4.6 stars. The hard part is done. This is about the part Facebook keeps taking back — and what it would actually take to fix it.

Prepared for

Infinite Lives · 40 Public Square, Watertown NY

From

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I'm not a marketing guy. I'm a customer.

Hi —

Before any of the business stuff, I want you to know where I'm coming from, because I think it matters for whether we'd work well together.

I've been playing Zelda since the original in 1986. Not "I've heard of it" — that game is the reason I like the things I like. These days I'm deep in the speedrunning side. I watch people like **LackAttack** run it and I'm genuinely in awe. I've tried to learn the strats myself and I'll be straight with you: **I'm not good enough**. I can follow what they're doing, I understand why it works, and then I pick up a controller and it turns out knowing and doing are very different things. So I watch, and I respect the hell out of the people who can.

That's also why I care about stores like yours. The retro scene, the speedrun scene, the Friday-night-tournament scene — none of it lives on Amazon. It lives in shops where somebody behind the counter knows what a complete-in-box cart is worth and why it matters. **Watertown has exactly one of those, and it's yours.**

What I actually looked at before writing this

4.6 stars across 315 Google reviews, in a town of about 25,000. 4,800 people following the Facebook page — call it one in five people in Watertown. 94% recommend. Open seven days a week. And you expanded into books, tabletop and dice instead of playing it safe. That's not luck and it isn't marketing. That's years of doing it right.

So this isn't a pitch where I tell you what you're doing wrong. You're not doing anything wrong. What follows is one specific thing being done *to* you, what it would cost to fix if you hired anybody else, what I charge instead, and what it has to earn to be worth it. **I've put every number in here rather than making you ask.**

THE ONE THING

You built the audience. Facebook decides who sees it.

Four days before I wrote this, you posted the PS5 Wolverine release on launch day — exactly the thing 4,800 people followed you for.

4,800

FOLLOW YOUR STORE



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REACTED TO THE POST

That's not a bad post. That's a platform deciding how many of **your own followers** get to see what you wrote. Organic reach for business pages has slid for a decade and it's still sliding. The only dependable way to reach the audience you built is to pay for it, every single time.

And because there's nowhere else to put things, the Facebook page is doing a website's job too. **Your cover photo is a picture of your store hours.** That's not a criticism — it's the only place you've got. But it means nobody can check stock before driving downtown, and the rewards program you just started lives at the counter, where people forget it exists.

What a follower is worth now

Close to nothing unless you pay. You don't own that list, you can't export it, and you can't reach it on demand. If Facebook changed its mind tomorrow, 4,800 relationships go with it.

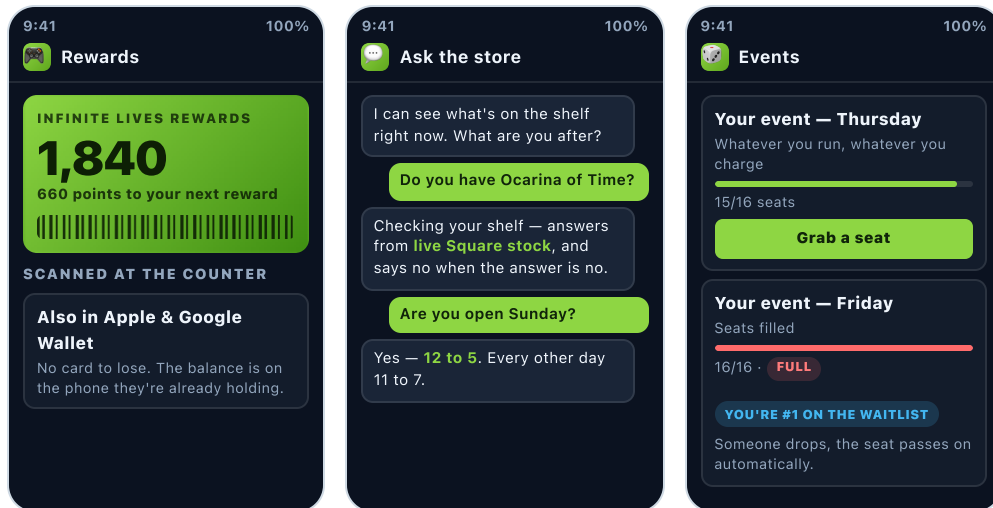
What a download is worth

Nobody filters a push notification. If 200 people want to know a Zelda cart came in, 200 people find out — every time, for free, forever, with no algorithm in between.

WHAT "CAN BE"

Your store, in their pocket.

There's a working version you can tap through on your phone — link on the last page. These are the real screens from it.



Example content only. I don't know your stock, your events or your prices yet — those are yours to set, and the app just shows whatever you're actually doing.

The rewards program you just started

Right now it's something people have to remember at the counter. Put the balance on their phone, show how close they are, and nudge them when they're near. Same program — somewhere they actually look.

The waitlist is the one to look at

If you hold 16 chairs and 10 people show, that's the problem this fixes. Full doesn't mean lost, it means queued — someone taps "can't make it" and the next person is in automatically. You never chase anyone.

And the things worth adding if you want them

Want lists — regulars tell you what they're hunting, so you know who to contact when it turns up. **Trade-in photos** — they send a picture and get a rough range before driving down. **Buy online** — through your own Square, so somebody who moves away from Drum can still buy from you. All optional. You tell me which of these you'd actually use.

What someone **else** would charge you to build this.

These are other developers' numbers, not mine. Here's the actual work hour by hour so you can price it against anybody you like. **My number is on page 7** — and it looks nothing like this.

THE WORK	HOURS
Discovery, wireframes, UI design	40 – 80
The app itself — one codebase, both stores	250 – 450
Backend, accounts, database	80 – 160
Square catalog + live inventory sync	40 – 90
AI assistant on your inventory	40 – 80
Loyalty engine + Apple/Google Wallet passes	30 – 70
Events, signups, waitlist logic	30 – 60
Online purchase + Square payments	40 – 80
Push + SMS plumbing, carrier registration	25 – 50
QA, device testing, App Store submission	50 – 100
Total	625 – 1,220 hrs

AT MARKET RATES

WHO YOU'D HIRE INSTEAD OF ME	THEIR RATE	WHAT THEY'D CHARGE
Offshore / budget freelancer	\$75/hr	\$46,875 – \$91,500
Experienced US freelancer	\$125/hr	\$78,125 – \$152,500
Small US agency	\$175/hr	\$109,375 – \$213,500
The website, separately	—	\$4,000 – \$12,000

From here on I use the **cheapest row** — **\$51,000 to \$103,500** all in, website included. I'm arguing against my own pitch on purpose.

Again — none of these are my numbers

This page is what you'd pay someone else to build it and hand it to you. **What I charge is on page 7.**

SIDE BY SIDE

Their way vs my way.

Same app, same features. **Red is what you'd pay somebody else. Teal is me.**

FIRST — IF YOU HIRE IT OUT, BUILDING IT DOESN'T END THE BILL

WHAT YOU'D KEEP PAYING EVERY MONTH, FOREVER	COST
Servers, database, storage	\$50 – \$200
AI usage	\$15 – \$60
Text messaging	\$15 – \$50
Maintenance — iOS and Android ship breaking changes twice a year the standard rule is 15–20% of the build cost per year	\$500 – \$1,200
Monthly, on top of the build	\$580 – \$1,500

An app nobody maintains stops opening in about eighteen months. That line isn't optional — it's the cost of the thing continuing to exist.

	HIRE SOMEONE (LOW)	HIRE SOMEONE (HIGH)	MY PRICE
Up front, before it opens once	\$51,000	\$103,500	\$0
Monthly after that	\$580	\$1,500	\$499
Total after year 1	\$57,960	\$121,500	\$5,988
Total after year 3	\$71,880	\$157,500	\$17,964
Total after year 5	\$85,800	\$193,500	\$29,940

Three things worth sitting with

- 1. Over five years, renting is between **2.9x and 6.5x cheaper** than owning it.
- 2. Even if somebody handed you the finished app *for free*, the running and maintenance costs (\$580–\$1,500/mo) are **more per month than renting the entire thing from me.**
- 3. Even the cheapest build — \$51,000 — is **8.5 years** of paying me, before a single month of maintenance on it.

What I'm not counting

Your time managing a developer. Scope creep.
The risk they disappear halfway. None of it is in the table above.

Where I could be wrong

You might find someone cheaper — a student, a friend, offshore. But the maintenance line doesn't go away no matter who builds it.

MY NUMBER

\$499 a month. Nothing up front.

\$499 / month

No build cost · No setup fee
I take **0%** of anything you sell

What's included

- ✓ A real website, built and run
- ✓ A real iPhone + Android app, both stores
- ✓ Rewards in the phone + Wallet passes
- ✓ Assistant reading live Square stock
- ✓ Events, reminders, automatic waitlist
- ✓ Unlimited push notifications
- ✓ 1,000 texts a month
- ✓ Buy online through your own Square
- ✓ Hosting, security, backups, updates
- ✓ I deal with Apple and Google, not you

What stays yours

- ✓ The Apple & Google accounts — your name
- ✓ The app listing, reviews, downloads
- ✓ Your Square and every dollar through it
- ✓ Your customer list and rewards balances
- ✓ Your domain

Fire me and you keep all of it. I build and run it, you own it. Nothing held hostage, no percentage for me to lose.

WHAT IT HAS TO EARN — AND I WON'T PROMISE YOU IT WILL

At a blended 35% gross margin, \$499/mo needs about **\$1,426 in extra sales a month — roughly \$48 a day.** In your units:

TO COVER THE FEE, PER MONTH	GROSS EACH	UNITS NEEDED	PER DAY
Pre-owned games @ \$30, 45% margin	\$13.50	37	1.2
TCG booster boxes @ \$100, 30%	\$30.00	17	0.6
Accessories @ \$60, 40%	\$24.00	21	0.7
New games @ \$65, 12%	\$7.80	64	2.1

Or just the event nights

Say you run one event a week and charge \$10 — swap in your real numbers, the shape holds:

12 players → 20 = 8 more seats = \$346/mo in entry + roughly \$182 gross on what those eight buy while standing in your shop = **\$528/mo — 106% of the fee from one night a week.**

Even a modest 10 → 16 covers 79% of it. I can't promise your events will fill. I can make sure everyone who'd want to come actually hears about it, which right now they don't.

Margins above are typical industry ranges, not your books. Texts over 1,000/mo are 2¢ each. Apple (\$99/yr) and Google (\$25 once) are paid by you directly, because those accounts are yours. That's every cost there is.

WHERE I'D LIKE THIS TO GO

Let me buy you lunch at Cam's.

Not a sales meeting. I want to talk about what a partnership between us actually looks like, and I'd rather do that over a booth than a calendar invite.

Tap through it first — nothing to sign up for

I built a working mockup of your app. Your name, your address, your hours. The rewards card, the assistant, event signup, and the waitlist doing its thing. Open it on your phone:

ainovations.net/demo/infinite-lives

Go to Events → the Friday event → Join the waitlist, then wait three seconds. That's the part I'd want for you most.

IF YOU WANT TO MOVE

- 1 Lunch at Cam's.** You tell me what actually eats your week, I show you the real thing on a laptop, and you decide if any of it is worth \$499 to you.
- 2 I look at your Square.** Read-only, ten minutes. I'll tell you honestly whether the live-stock part will work *before* you commit to anything.
- 3 Website goes up first.** It's the quick one, and it starts working while the app is still in review.
- 4 The app takes 4–6 weeks** — that's Apple and Google, not me. Texts need carrier registration on top, another 1–3 weeks. Nothing goes live until you've approved it.

One thing I'd rather say now than later

Apple only issues business developer accounts to registered entities. If Infinite Lives isn't an LLC yet, that's a step we'd need to sort first. Not hard, but I'm not going to pretend it isn't there.

Either way — thanks for running the kind of store I grew up needing. I hope I get to see it.

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